fallen back from Bum-la and Tawang were sitting around on the convoy ground, waiting for motor transport to take them up the zig-zagging road to Se-la and beyond.

At the convoy ground ‘the scene was akin to a cattle fair in India. Hundreds of men with a sprinkling of officers sat around in aimless groups. Some were making up for lost sleep but the enterprising types were brewing tea.’ Major General Niranjan Prasad having already relocated to Dirang, the seniormost officer was the 4 Artillery Brigade commander, Brigadier Kalyan Singh, who along with other officers had occupied the Border Roads officers’ mess.

Confusion continued to prevail at another level. Niranjan Prasad, while abandoning Tawang, had stated that Se-la would be the next defensive line, whereas Bogey Sen had indicated that it would be Bomdila. Unfortunately, there was no senior infantry officer at Jang, for its natural defensive potential would have been obvious. The steep slopes on either side of the fast-flowing Tawang Chu meant that the distance between the two sides as the crow flies was negligible. If the Chinese got down to the river and crossed over to the south bank, Indian guns positioned further back around Bridge 3 at Nuranang, controlled by forward observers, could extract a heavy toll.

After a dull, uneventful morning and afternoon, suddenly there was a wave of excitement on the convoy ground: a bunch of Chinese soldiers had appeared on the other bank. Sitting in the officers’ mess, Kalyan Singh and his officers, who were sipping their evening tea and enjoying their salted almonds, had seen them too. Hurriedly, binoculars were asked for after which Kalyan Singh in his calm manner started describing what the Chinese were doing. Their mortar crews went about systematically setting up the weapons; they then took their compass bearings, aligned and loaded the mortars. Lieutenant Colonel Bhupinder Singh, commanding 22 Field Regiment, who had been an instructor at gunnery school, thought the Chinese performance was commendable.

Describing the scenario further, Khullar says: ‘The scene around the convoy ground was equally curious. Most of the men had had no food the whole day and they were bored. The appearance of the Chinese on the other side had helped to break the monotony. A decade plus of peace time unrealistic training against dummy enemy in exercises and camps had dimmed the warlike instincts of our army. I wonder what the Chinese must